Engaging Washington

If one is to go by popular discourse, many officials in countries such as Russia, Iran, and India, believed that Washington was tacitly supporting the rise of the Taliban. The US involvement in the region, however complex it may be in reality, was reduced to a caricature of an energy-hungry capitalist. Topping this, many Indian officials were convinced that Washington viewed Pakistan as the lynchpin of its South Asia strategy, and was going soft on the Pakistan-Taliban nexus.[51] If the US defended its South Asian policy as being balanced and pragmatic, as it often did, Indians derided it as being simplistic.[52] The fact was that US officials were concerned about the Taliban's rise within Afghanistan and its support to Kashmiri militants. The same month when Gujral had briefed the Parliament about Taliban's alleged training to HuA in November 1996, US Ambassador to Pakistan Thomas W. Simons had confronted Taliban's 'Acting Foreign Minister' Mullah Ghaus about the HuA bases in Taliban-controlled territories in Khost.[53] Noting that the US was concerned about HuA's activities, Simon threatened that the US might declare HuA a terrorist organisation. But Ghaus flatly denied the allegations.[54] Simons was neither convinced nor impressed. Nor was Walter Andersen, then Chief of the South Asia Directorate in the State Department. 'The Taliban knew that training of Kashmiri militants was under way in Afghanistan ... engaging the Taliban [in such circumstances] would have been a very difficult choice for the Indian government', Andersen argues.[55] The US continued to unofficially engage with the Taliban regardless.

The Africa bombings and the US response of launching cruise missiles in Afghanistan (and Sudan) gave India an opportunity to steer US policy closer to its own political wavelength. In his interactions with the then Deputy Secretary of State Strobe Talbott, Jaswant Singh emphasised that 'the Taliban is a creature of Pakistan, and now Pakistan is in danger of becoming a creature of the Taliban'. He wondered why the East African bombings had not 'made the scales fall from your [US] eyes' about Pakistan?[56] Afghanistan itself was not the top priority of this dialogue, but the Taliban had become an adjunct to India and Pakistan's bilateral issues. Astutely playing US anxieties over terrorism to India's advantage, Vajpayee shifted tack by asserting that the India-US dialogue had been 'altered by